The agent rollout ladder

Five stages to take one AI agent from a demo to production work, one workflow at a time.

40%+

of agentic AI projects will be canceled by the end of 2027, for cost, unclear value or weak risk controls.

Gartner prediction, June 2025

17%

of organizations have deployed AI agents so far. More than 60% expect to within two years.

Gartner, April 2026

~75%

of AI high performers redesigned workflows around AI, against about 25% of everyone else.

McKinsey State of AI, Aug 2026

For CIOs and the operations and engineering leaders putting agents into real workflows

Swipe →

01

Pick a job, not a technology

Start with one workflow that has volume, a clear definition of done and an owner.

- Write down today’s cost per task: time, error rate and who fixes the errors.
- Try the simplest design that could work first: one model call, then a fixed sequence of steps, and only then an agent that chooses its own steps.

> **Working when:** One page states the task, the baseline and what good looks like.

02

Build the test set before the agent

Collect 20 to 50 real cases with the outcome you expect, starting with the ones that went wrong before.

- Grade automatically where an answer can be checked, and have a person grade the rest.
- Rerun the full set after every prompt, tool or model change.

> **Working when:** A change can be tested in minutes, not argued about in a meeting.

03

Run it in shadow mode

The agent drafts and people decide. Nothing it does reaches a customer or a system of record yet.

- Compare its output with what the person did, on real work, for at least two weeks.
- Log every model call and tool call, so you can see why it went wrong.

> **Working when:** You know its agreement rate on real traffic, not on a demo.

04

Add guardrails and handoffs

Decide in advance what the agent may do alone, what needs approval and when it stops.

- Give it the fewest permissions that do the job, and require a person to approve anything irreversible: payments, deletions, outside email.
- Hand off to a person after repeated failures or on high-risk requests, and give each agent its own budget at the gateway.

> **Working when:** Every action the agent can take is on a list with an owner.

05

Scale on evidence

Widen in steps, such as 10%, then 50%, then all of the work, and only while the numbers hold.

- Review cost per task, error rate and handoffs every month against the baseline from stage 1.
- Reuse the gateway, test harness and logs for the second workflow. That is where the next one gets cheaper.

> **Working when:** Cost per task and error rate both beat the baseline.

Track every month

- Cost per completed task, against the stage 1 baseline
- Share of tasks handed to a person
- Test pass rate after each change
- Errors found in review
- Model and tool calls per task

Take the whole framework

Free, with sources for every number, and open source so you can copy it into your own wiki.

Read it, with sources

steeltownai.io/blog

Copy it, plus free agent skills

steeltownai.io/open-source

Talk it through

A free 30-minute call at steeltownai.io